scientists of extremely high calibre over the years.

The real journey of the Indian aerospace programme, however, had begun with the Rohini Sounding Rocket (RSR) Programme. What is it that distinguishes a sounding rocket from a Satel ite Launch Vehicle (SLV) and from a missile? In fact, they are three different kinds of rockets. Sounding rockets are normal y used for probing the near-earth environment, including the upper regions of the atmosphere. While they can carry a variety of scientific payloads to a range of altitudes, they cannot impart the final velocity needed to orbit the payload. On the other hand, a launch vehicle is designed to inject into orbit a technological payload or satel ite. The final stage of a launch vehicle provides the necessary velocity for a satel ite to enter an orbit. This is a complex operation requiring on-board guidance and control systems. A missile, though belonging to the same family, is a stil more complex system. In addition to the large terminal velocity and onboard guidance and control, it must have the capability to home onto targets. When the targets are fast-moving and capable of manoeuvring, a missile is also required to carry out target-tracking functions.